1.2 Western American Cultures

How do you get food if you can't grow it—or buy it? You work with what you've got. Like the Mesoamericans and South Americans, people in the north adapted to their environments.

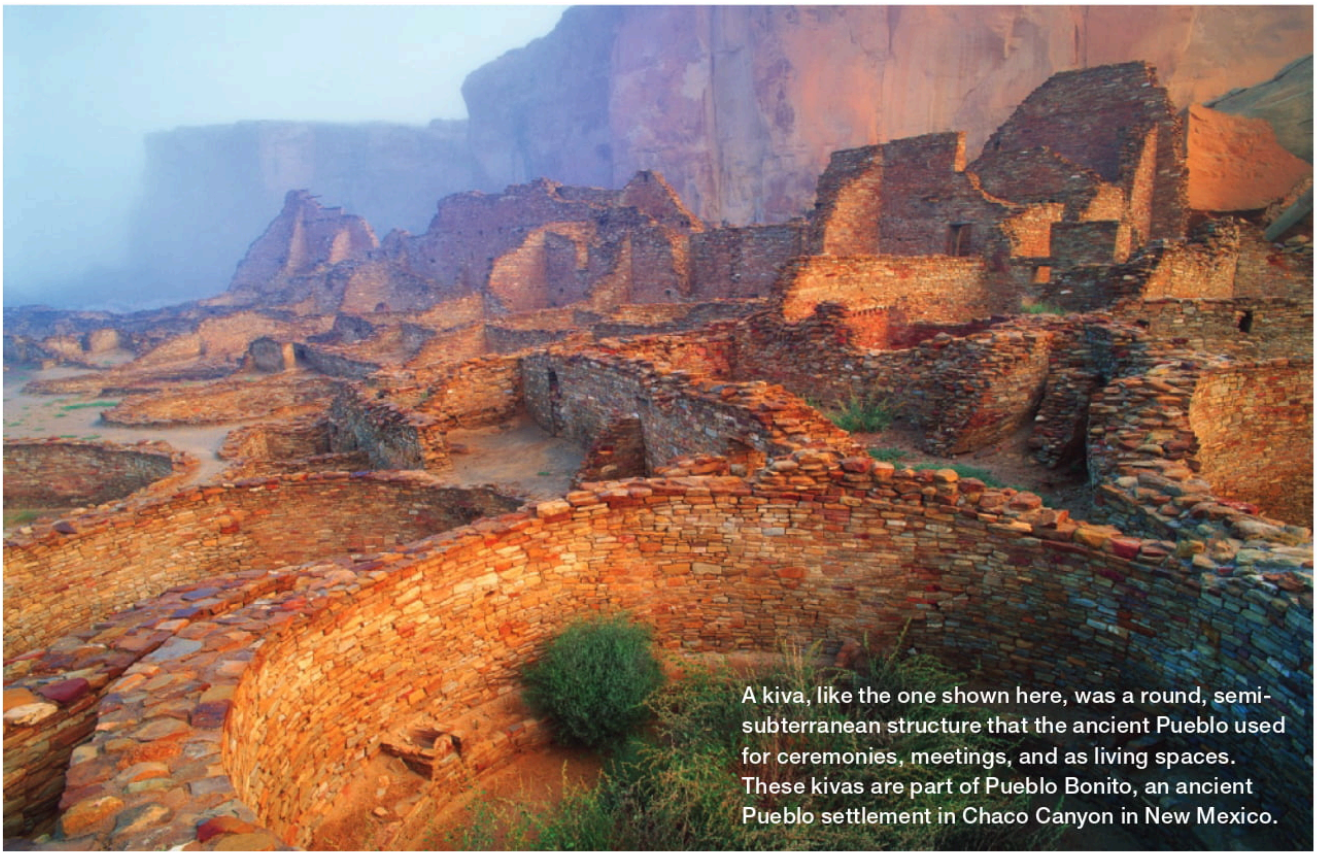
MAIN IDEA A variety of environments, characterized by climate and landforms, influenced the development of western North American cultures.

THE FAR NORTH AND PACIFIC COAST

South America and Mesoamerica weren't the only places where civilizations developed in the Western Hemisphere. In the extreme northwest of North America, several Native American groups flourished in particularly harsh climates. The Aleut (a-lee-OOT) lived on the cold, nearly treeless islands off the coast of what is now Alaska. The Inuit (IH-noo-wit) lived on the flat, frozen Arctic **tundra** of present-day Alaska and northwestern Canada. Since the weather did not favor growing crops, the groups fished and hunted sea mammals for food. They used **kayaks**, light boats made of wood and seal or walrus hides.

Farther to the south, a number of tribes lived in the evergreen forests that swept down the coast from present-day British Columbia to Oregon. Groups such as the Kwakiutl (kwah-kee-YOO-tuhl) and Haida (HI-duh) hunted and fished, and the ocean provided plenty of food. The abundance of trees made wood the preferred material for houses, boats, and household goods. The Kwakiutl also hosted **potlatches**, feasts where families gave gifts to guests to show social rank and wealth.

Even farther down the coast, in what is now California, the Pomo lived as hunter-gatherers. The Pomo didn't need to farm because the



A kiva, like the one shown here, was a round, semi-subterranean structure that the ancient Pueblo used for ceremonies, meetings, and as living spaces. These kivas are part of Pueblo Bonito, an ancient Pueblo settlement in Chaco Canyon in New Mexico.

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streams were full of fish, and plenty of edible wild plants, nuts, and berries grew on the land. The Pomo had a unique religion. Worshippers dressed as animal spirits and other beings to sing, dance, and distribute gifts.

THE DESERTS AND PLAINS

Like the people of the North and the West, Native Americans living in the Southwest and Great Plains had to adapt to special climates and conditions. In the arid American Southwest, the **ancient Pueblo** (PWAY-bloh) and the **Hohokam** (ho-ho-KOM) thrived during the time of the Maya. In fact, Mesoamerican culture heavily influenced these groups. Not only did the Hohokam trade with Mesoamericans, they also **domesticated**, or grew, similar crops for food. They irrigated their crops in the dry climate. The Hohokam grew cotton, squash, beans, and maize, or corn, by digging canals from their fields to nearby rivers. Having extra food allowed the population to grow.



Around A.D. 1000, both the Hohokam and the ancient Pueblo built large adobe (uh-DOH-bee) homes made of sun-dried clay and straw bricks. These dwellings were similar to apartment buildings with multiple floors. For example, Pueblo Bonito, pictured to the left, once had as many as five floors and at least 600 rooms.

The ancient Pueblo were once referred to as the Anasazi, a name given them by the Navajo. In the 1990s, descendants of the ancient Pueblo protested the use of the term, pointing out that it means "enemy ancestor." Today many historians use the term "ancient Pueblo."

Northeast of the Hohokam, the Great Plains tribes experienced a very different way of life. Vast grasslands stretched from the Mississippi River to the Rocky Mountains. Native Americans who lived in the eastern part of the Great Plains, such as the Mandan and Pawnee, lived the settled lives of farmers, building villages of earthen lodges. In the western grasslands, the Blackfoot and other tribes like them **migrated**, or moved from place to place, hunting herds of bison (also commonly called buffalo) and other game for food and clothing. **Tepees**, or tents made of bison hides, served as their portable homes.

At this time, tribes herded bison on foot. They steered the animals over cliffs or into corrals where men could kill them with arrows. Nonetheless, Plains Indian tribes considered the bison sacred. They used every part of the animal: meat for food, skin and fur for clothes and tepees, and bones for tools and crafts.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did the tribes of northern and western North America adapt to their environments?
2. **COMPARE AND CONTRAST** How did lifestyles differ among Great Plains tribes?
3. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** What can you conclude about similarities between the Maya culture and those of the ancient Pueblo and the Hohokam?

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